

UN Reforms: A Simple & Complete Guide

The United Nations was created in 1945, after the Second World War. Its main aim is to help countries prevent conflict, work together and deal with problems that cross borders.

The UN is not just one body. It has six main organs and a wider network of agencies and organisations. Each has a different job. When people call for “UN reform,” they may mean changing the Security Council, improving the way other UN bodies work, or making the whole system more effective.

The six main organs of the UN

1. General Assembly

The General Assembly is where all **193 UN member countries** meet. Each country has one vote. Members discuss global issues, approve the UN budget and elect members to some other UN bodies.

Most General Assembly resolutions are recommendations. They can carry political weight, but they are generally not legally binding orders to countries.

2. Security Council

The Security Council deals with international peace and security. It has **15 members**:

- **Five permanent members:** China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom and the United States.
- **Ten elected members:** chosen for two-year terms.

Each permanent member has a **veto**. This means one of them can block a major decision, even if most other Council members support it. The Council can impose sanctions or establish peacekeeping operations. Under the UN Charter, member countries agree to carry out its decisions.

This is the body at the centre of most UN reform proposals. When India, the G4 or African countries call for new permanent seats, they mean permanent seats **on the Security Council**. They are not asking for permanent seats in the General Assembly, where all UN members already have a place.

3. Economic and Social Council (ECOSOC)

ECOSOC brings countries together to discuss economic, social and development issues, including poverty, education, health and progress towards the Sustainable Development Goals.

4. International Court of Justice (ICJ)

The ICJ is the UN's main court. It settles some legal disputes between countries and gives legal opinions when authorized UN bodies ask it to.

The ICJ is different from the **International Criminal Court (ICC)**, which is a separate organisation that tries individuals accused of certain serious crimes.

5. Secretariat

The Secretariat carries out the UN's daily work. It is led by the Secretary-General and supports diplomacy, meetings, research, humanitarian work and peacekeeping missions.

6. Trusteeship Council

The Trusteeship Council helped territories move towards self-government and independence. After the last UN trust territory became independent, it stopped its regular work in 1994.

These six organs are set out in the UN Charter. [UN: Main Bodies](#)

Other organisations in the UN system

The UN system also includes programmes, funds and specialised agencies. They have different roles and ways of working; they are not all departments of the UN itself.

- **WHO (World Health Organization):** helps countries work together on health.
- **UNICEF (United Nations Children's Fund):** supports children's health, education, protection and rights.
- **WFP (World Food Programme):** provides food and emergency assistance.
- **FAO (Food and Agriculture Organization):** works on farming, food security and hunger.
- **UNHCR (UN Refugee Agency):** protects refugees and displaced people.
- **UNDP (United Nations Development Programme):** supports development, poverty reduction and recovery after crises.
- **UNESCO:** works on education, science, culture and heritage.
- **ILO (International Labour Organization):** works on workers' rights and labour standards.
- **UN Women:** supports gender equality and women's empowerment.
- **UNFPA (United Nations Population Fund):** works on reproductive and maternal health, population data and young people's wellbeing.
- **UNEP (United Nations Environment Programme):** works on environmental issues.
- **UN-Habitat:** works on housing and sustainable cities.
- **IMF and World Bank:** support international financial cooperation and development. They are part of the wider UN system, but they have their own leadership and membership arrangements.

The UN system also includes organisations that work on aviation, shipping, communications, migration, nuclear energy and other issues. [UN: The UN System](#)

Why are countries calling for reform?

Many countries argue that the Security Council's permanent membership reflects the balance of power in 1945, when the UN was founded, and does not adequately represent today's world.

For example, Africa has no permanent seat, and Latin America and the Caribbean have none either. Countries such as India also argue that major developing countries should have a permanent place in the Council.

Another concern is the veto. A single permanent member can block a Council decision. Some countries argue that this can prevent action even when most members support it.

What different countries and groups are proposing

Countries agree that the Council should be discussed and possibly changed, but they do **not** agree on one reform plan. They differ over which countries or regions should get new seats, how many seats to add and whether new permanent members should have the veto.

India and the G4

The **G4** consists of India, Brazil, Germany and Japan. It proposes expanding the **UN Security Council** by adding:

- Six new permanent seats: two for Africa, two for Asia-Pacific, one for Latin America and the Caribbean, and one for Western Europe and Others.
- Four or five additional elected seats.

India's own main aim is to become a **permanent member of the Security Council**. The G4 also says that new permanent members should not be left with fewer rights forever if the current permanent members keep their veto. [G4 statement, January 2026](#)

African countries

The African Union's position, known as the **Ezulwini Consensus**, calls for African countries to receive **two permanent seats and five elected seats on the UN Security Council**.

The African Union says that African countries holding new permanent seats should have the same rights as the current permanent members, including the veto for as long as the veto exists.

L.69 group

The **L.69 group** is a group of developing countries from different regions. It supports expanding both the permanent and elected membership of the Security Council and giving developing countries a stronger voice. India works with this group as well as with the G4.

Uniting for Consensus group

The **Uniting for Consensus group** includes countries such as Italy, Pakistan, Mexico, Argentina and South Korea. It opposes adding new permanent seats to the Security Council.

It argues that adding more permanent members could create another privileged group. Instead, it favours adding more elected seats, including some with longer terms or the possibility of re-election.

The current permanent members

China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom and the United States are the five current permanent members of the Security Council. They do not all have the same position on every reform proposal. However, any Charter change needs the approval of all five, so their agreement is essential.

The UN's reform discussions cover issues such as the size of the Council, the kinds of seats it should have, regional representation, the veto and the Council's working methods. [UN Security Council reform negotiations](#)

What are the main disagreements?

The biggest disagreements are:

1. **Should new permanent seats be created?**
The G4 and African Union say yes. Uniting for Consensus says no and favours more elected seats.
2. **Which regions should receive new seats?**
Countries agree that some regions are under-represented, but they differ over how many seats each region should get and which countries should fill them.
3. **Should new permanent members get the veto?**
India, the G4 and the African Union argue that new permanent members should not be permanently given fewer rights than the current five. Some other countries oppose extending the veto, because they fear it could make the Council even less able to act.
4. **How should the Council work?**
Many countries also want more transparency and better communication between the Security Council and the General Assembly.

Why is it difficult to change the Security Council?

Changing the Council requires changing the UN Charter. Under Article 108, a Charter amendment must be approved by two-thirds of the General Assembly and ratified by two-thirds of UN members, including **all five current permanent members of the Security Council**. That makes agreement difficult. [UN Charter, Article 108](#)

A discussion-ready summary

“The United Nations has six main organs, along with many agencies that work on health, food, children, refugees, development and other issues. The main reform debate is about the Security Council, which has five permanent members with veto power and ten elected members. India, through the G4, wants a permanent Security Council seat and supports adding more permanent and elected seats. The African Union wants two permanent and five elected Security Council seats for African countries. The Uniting for Consensus group

opposes creating new permanent seats and instead wants more elected seats. The biggest disagreements are who should receive new seats and whether new permanent members should have the veto. The General Assembly is where all UN member countries meet; the proposed new permanent seats would be on the Security Council.”

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